Name:	Date:

Read the selection and choose the best answer to each question.

Corsets, Bloomers, and Blue Jeans

1 The clothing that women wear in any given society tells a great deal about that society's values. What does it mean that, for about 400 years, women wore corsets to force their figures into unnatural shapes? What does it indicate that they eventually shed those corsets and started wearing looser clothing? When bloomers replaced skirts, what changes were occurring in society? And when blue jeans were first invented and then later became popular with both men and women, how did that reflect changing societal values?

2 The corset had been popular since Shakespeare's day, during the reign of Queen Elizabeth I of England in the 1500s. Worn primarily by aristocratic women, it was one way to signal a woman's social status. Corsets, with very little variation in shape, continued to be the mark of an upper-class woman until the early 1800s. The corset of this time made a woman's torso look like a straight-sided, inverted cone.

3 In the early 1800s, women stopped wearing corsets temporarily. The French Revolution had just ended, and people were consciously renouncing the symbols of the aristocracy. The new freedom of movement allowed by looser-fitting clothes seemed to parallel the new ideas of freedom in political life.

4 Within a few years, though, the corset returned, this time with a different goal—instead of hiding the natural curves of a woman's body, this new corset accentuated them. Throughout the 1800s, this shape, with tight compression of the waist, became increasingly exaggerated. As the corset squeezed in more and more of the waist, it created an hourglass figure, which was regarded as the "ideal" female shape.

5 By the early 1900s, objections to the corset came from three different sources: physicians, religious leaders, and feminists. Physicians objected for two reasons: first, the corset had a negative impact on proper muscle development; second, it prevented vigorous exercise. Religious leaders denounced the way the corset exaggerated the female shape. Feminists resented the corset and considered it a symbol of the imprisonment of women. This undergarment finally fell out of favor entirely as clothing became less structured during the 1920s.

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6 Another trend in fashion that revealed changing societal attitudes was “rational dress” for women. This outfit included a short jacket and billowy trousers that were gathered at the ankle. Called the “Bloomer costume,” or just “bloomers,” this style was named after Amelia Bloomer, an American reformer and feminist. Bloomer did not design this costume, but she began wearing it in public as she spoke in favor of temperance reform and women’s rights. Bloomers eventually fell out of fashion, but the avant-garde idea that women could wear pants instead of dresses and skirts had been introduced and would soon be accepted.

Bloomers allowed women to be more physically active.

7 Perhaps the most influential innovation in fashion began with the invention of denim blue jeans. Levi Strauss was a 24-year-old German immigrant who left New York and traveled to San Francisco in 1853 to open a branch of his brother’s dry goods business. Once in San Francisco, Strauss encountered prospectors who struggled to find pants that were strong enough to endure hard labor in the gold mines. Strauss used rough canvas from tent and wagon covers to make pants for the miners. The pants were functional but uncomfortable. So Strauss began using a softer twilled cotton cloth from Nimes, France, called “serge de Nimes,” which later became known as denim.

8 Strauss learned about an innovation one of his customers had developed to make denim pants last longer. Jacob Davis was a tailor who started using rivets at the points of strain on the pants. Davis needed a business partner to promote his idea, so Strauss agreed to help. On May 20, 1873, they obtained a U.S. patent on Davis’s idea. The date marks the official invention of blue jeans. Even though the denim pants that Strauss had been making earlier had been popular for twenty years, the act of putting rivets on them made them into what we now call “jeans.” Today, blue jeans are practically a uniform for men and women alike.

9 Popular fashion has changed drastically over the last 500 years, from corsets to blue jeans. Perhaps the global popularity of jeans is a reflection of society’s evolving attitudes. Blue jeans and other clothing that allows for more freedom of movement suggests a society that values freedom and equality.

27. In what way does the text structure of the essay relate to the thesis it supports?

A The compare-and-contrast format points out the superiority of certain styles of women's clothing.

B The pattern of questions and answers suggests that women's clothing choices are questionable.

C The advantages-and-disadvantages pattern leads to the idea that jeans deserve their popularity.

D The chronological order shows how attitudes about women's clothing have evolved over time.

28. Read this sentence from paragraph 6.

> Bloomers eventually fell out of fashion, but the avant-garde idea that women could wear pants instead of dresses and skirts had been introduced and would soon be accepted.

Based on the context, what is the **most likely** meaning of the foreign loanword *avant-garde*?

A out of date

B lacking value

C highly praised

D ahead of its time

29. Which sentence **best** supports the key idea that blue jeans were invented to fill a need rather than to make a fashion statement?

A "Once in San Francisco, Strauss encountered prospectors who struggled to find pants that were strong enough to endure hard labor in the gold mines." (paragraph 7)

B "Strauss used rough canvas from tent and wagon covers to make pants for the miners." (paragraph 7)

C "The pants were functional but uncomfortable." (paragraph 7)

D "So Strauss began using a softer twilled cotton cloth from Nimes, France, called 'serge de Nimes,' which later became known as denim." (paragraph 7)

30. The author's inclusion of the photo after paragraph 6 is effective for the purpose of—

A helping readers visualize the details of the bloomers costume in context.
B helping readers connect bloomers to the recommendation for exercise.
C illustrating the changing attitudes in society toward women and dress.
D conveying additional information about how bloomers are made.

31 The following question has two parts. Answer Part A first, and then Part B.

Part A Which sentence **best** describes a main reason that corsets eventually fell out of fashion?

A Women demanded more form-fitting clothing.
B Physicians warned against exercise in the 1900s.
C Religious leaders demanded that women hide their figures.
D Leading voices came to oppose the corset for a variety of reasons.

Part B Which sentence **most clearly** supports the answer to Part A?

A "Worn primarily by aristocratic women, it was one way to signal a woman's social status." (paragraph 2)
B "The corset of this time made a woman's torso look like a straight-sided, inverted cone." (paragraph 2)
C "Throughout the 1800s, this shape, with tight compression of the waist, became increasingly exaggerated." (paragraph 4)
D "Feminists resented the corset and considered it a symbol of the imprisonment of women." (paragraph 5)